

The Guardians of Elaria

Session 8: Underroot • working draft for review

Session 8, Part One: The Year Apart

The Guardians of Elaria

1. Seven Days Early

Read aloud. *The Artificer's Guild never really sleeps, but at this hour it comes close. Down in the Underworks the furnaces are banked to a low orange mutter, and the great ring of the portal stands in the middle of the Rift Hall like something dreaming.*

It is finished. After ten years of Guildmaster Vane's life, it is finished, and it has been finished for eleven days, and nobody has dared to switch it on.

You have been here a week. You told yourself it was to check the anchor housing. It was really because you could not stand another night of waiting somewhere else.

ART A: the finished ring. The Rift Hall at low light, the completed portal standing dark and enormous, one small gnome girl alone at its foot with a lantern. Establishing shot; this is the first image of the session.

Lilly arrives a full week before the appointed day. Vane puts her on the anchor cradle, the empty brass socket at the ring's heart that has waited a decade for the Essence Sphere, and the two of them argue happily for six days about tolerances.

Three things to land during this week:

- **Vane has aged.** Ten years of work ended eleven days ago and he does not know what to do with his hands. He is louder than usual and sleeping less. He will not say he is frightened.
- **Lilly is the expert now.** The guild artificers ask her opinion and mean it. Let her player feel the difference from Session 7, when she was the clever kid in a city of masters.
- **The cradle does not quite fit.** It was built from Vane's drawings of a sphere he had only ever had described to him. When Lilly finally sets the real thing in on the sixth night, the brass closes around it as though it were cut for it, because the ancient thing inside has a shape his guesses kept circling. Play this quiet. It is the first hint of what she learned.

2. The Professor

He arrives on the fifth day with three trunks and no help whatsoever, which is very much his own choice, and with Lickgloom riding on top of the luggage looking enormously pleased with itself.

The party last saw **Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone** at Ravenstone Laboratory in Session 3, when he examined the Essence Sphere, told them it needed Gearhaven, and gave Ursa a companion. He has spent the years since on the planar problem. He is here because Vane wrote to him, and because a portal without a planar theorist is a very expensive hole in the air.

Read aloud. *He is exactly as you remember him and slightly worse: tall, silver haired, entirely certain, and delighted to be proven wrong about anything as long as he is the one doing the proving. He looks at the ring for a long moment, and then at the Sphere in its cradle, and then he says, to nobody in particular:*

"Oh. That is much older than you think it is."

He says it the way other people say good morning.

ART B: Aelwyn's arrival. The professor in the Rift Hall doorway with his trunks, Lickgloom perched on top of the luggage mid-tongue-flick, the ring huge and out of focus beyond. No assistant.

Lickgloom remembers them. He stayed behind at Ravenstone Laboratory in Session 3 and has spent two years licking a professor's equipment. He recognises the party instantly and is beside himself about it. Give this a beat: it is the only uncomplicated happy reunion in the whole session.

His function this session is to be the one adult who can explain the rules, and the one adult honest enough to say which parts he is guessing at. He is not a rescuer and he does not come through the portal.

3. Dawn, and the Eastern Gate

Read aloud. *He comes in with the dawn traffic, on foot, with road dust to his knees.*

He is taller. That is the first thing. The second thing is that he is quiet in a way he never used to be, and he waits half a beat before he answers you, as though he is listening to something a half second behind your voice. There is a stone in his left hand that he turns over and over without seeming to know that he is doing it.

He has been walking east for a year. He does not look like someone who found what he was looking for. He does not look like someone who failed, either.

ART C: Ursa at the gate. Dawn, the eastern gate of Gearhaven, a small road-worn figure with a staff coming in against the traffic. Warm light, long shadow.

Let Ursa's player set the tone of the reunion. He went looking for his father and this is the first the others have heard of any of it.

4. Ten to Midnight

Read aloud. *The bell over the Rift Hall doors has not rung all evening. It does not ring now either, because the goblin coming through them does not touch them.*

He is on the rail above you before anybody thinks to look up. He is leaner, and there is a new sword across his back, dark and quiet, and when he drops down into the lamplight he lands without a sound, which he absolutely never used to do.

"I'm not late," says Stabby Sharpblade. "It's still today."

He is right. He has ten minutes in hand. He has almost certainly been in Gearhaven since the afternoon.

ART D: the arrival from above. Low angle, the goblin dropping from the rafter rail into lamplight, new blade on his back, the ring's shoulder visible behind.

The idol

When Stabby swings his pack down, something inside it knocks against the flagstones with a dull, wrong sound.

It is the small carved idol that appeared in his bag after Wraithpine, which nobody has ever explained and which no one saw put there. Here in the Rift Hall, forty feet from a portal that is not even lit, **it is cold enough to burn.** He has carried it for a year and it has never once done that before.

Do not explain it. Let it sit there. (*Canon must-mention for this session. It is the seed of the Shadow road he did not take.*)

5. The Year Apart

Give each player the floor. Read their chapter in full. The order below builds best: Lilly's is the most hopeful, Stabby's is the loudest, and Ursa's changes the shape of the campaign, so it goes last.

READ IN FULL: year_apart_lilly.md.

*Her mother did not make the Essence Sphere. She found it. The thing inside the brass is ancient, it is a **gatherer**, and you cannot pick a gatherer's lock, you can only give it something to gather.*

READ IN FULL: year_apart_stabby.md.

*His father was the Fourth. The night Stabby was born, the Fourth sealed the **Red Fang** into his newborn son and died doing it, which is why no clan art ever took with him. He went to a mountain of bullywugs, learned to be still for one second, came home and burned the blight out of the ground, and is now the hero of the Hollow.*

READ IN FULL: year_apart_ursa.md.

*He walked east alone for eleven months and did not find his father. He found the camp, three years cold instead of fifteen, and a half-carved stone, and at the shrine **Elaria showed him three things**: that Ash went east to save the stars, that **Maldrith** is behind their going out, and that a shadow walks for her called **Nyxthid**.*

This is the most important moment of the evening. Ursa comes home from that shrine with a name to hunt, and swears out loud to hunt it, and the name belongs to his own father. Nobody at the table knows that except you. Let the other two players get excited about having an enemy at last.

ART E, F, G, H: one plate per chapter, plus one extra for Ursa. Detail below in the art list; the individual chapters carry their own illustration slots.

6. The Handover

The morning before they step through, on the long bench in the Underworks.

Read aloud. *Lilly has been awake since four. There is a cloth on the bench for each of you, which is a very Lilly way of doing things, and she has clearly rehearsed this speech, and she gets about six words into it before she gives up and just starts handing things over.*

ART: already made. assets/session_08/lilly_gifts_laid_out.png

For Stabby: Wraps of Unarmed Power +2

"Give me your hands. No, the fists. Both of them."

How they work, in kid words: wind them on and forget them. There is nothing to activate, nothing to spend, and nothing to run out. Every punch and kick is now **+2 to hit and +2 damage**, and he may choose to make any of those hits deal **Force** instead of bludgeoning, which almost nothing in the world resists.

What to say out loud at the table: *your fists were the only weapon you owned with no magic in them, and now they are not.* His bonus-action punch happens nearly every turn, so this is not a small gift.

The one thing he will get wrong: they do nothing for the katana. Nothing at all. The Nichirin is already +2 on its own and the wraps never stack with it.

For Ursa: Wand of the War Mage +2

"You have to be holding it. Not in your pack. Not on your belt. In your hand, the one without the staff."

How it works: while he holds it, every **spell attack** he makes gets **+2 to hit**, and he ignores **Half Cover**. That is Starry Wisp, his Guiding Bolts, and his star-arrow, all to **+10**.

The one thing he will get wrong: it does *not* raise his save DC. Spells where the enemy rolls a save (Spike Growth, Ice Storm, Polymorph) are unaffected. It only helps when *he* rolls to hit.

Table note: the star-arrow counts, because Starry Form's arrow is a ranged spell attack. That means the wand improves two attacks a turn, not one. Make sure his player knows.

For Lilly: Wand of Web

"This one is mine. I have earned exactly one selfish thing."

How it works: 7 charges. Spend 1 as an action to cast **Web**: a 20-foot cube of sticky webbing that is difficult terrain, and anything caught in it makes a **Dexterity save or is Restrained**, escaping later with a Strength check. It regains **1d6+1 charges at dawn**.

The one thing everyone will get wrong: the wand casts at **DC 13**, its own number, *not* Lilly's DC 16. Items cast at their own difficulty. Say this once at the table and write it on her sheet, which is already done.

For Puff: the three small things

Puff gets a set of her own, and this needs the most explaining, because a homunculus has **one action on her turn** and three items to choose between. She cannot use two in a round.

Ring of Spell Storing (worn, attuned to Puff). This one is a *shared* item and the party will miss it if nobody explains it.

- It is **empty when you get it**. It does nothing until somebody loads it.
- **Any caster** can load it: touch the ring while casting a spell of level 1 to 5, and the spell goes in instead of going off. It holds **5 levels of spells** in total.
- Puff can then cast anything stored inside, using **the original caster's** slot level, save DC, and attack bonus. A spell Lilly puts in comes back out at **DC 16 and +8**, even though Puff herself is a little brass construct with no magic of her own.
- **The tactical point:** this is how the party gets a second Revivify, or a second Healing Word, or a big spell on a turn when the caster is busy or unconscious. Encourage them to load it every morning and to think hard about what goes in.

Wand of Magic Missiles (no attunement, so Puff can use it). **7 charges**. Spend **1 charge** for **three darts that never miss**, 1d4+1 Force each, at up to 120 feet, split between any targets she can see. She may spend up to **3 charges at once**, and each extra charge adds one more dart, so three charges means **five darts**. Regains 1d6+1 at dawn.

- **Why it matters:** Puff's own attack is unreliable. Darts that cannot miss are perfect for finishing something on 3 hit points, or for hitting a target nobody else can reach.

Pipes of Haunting (no attunement). **3 charges**, regaining 1d3 at dawn. A **Magic action** to play: every creature Puff chooses within **30 feet** makes a **Wisdom save DC 15** or is **Frightened for a minute**, re-saving at the end of each of its turns. Anything that saves is immune to the pipes for a day.

- **Why it matters:** it is the party's only crowd control that costs no spell slot, and Frightened enemies cannot approach the source of their fear.

The handout table

Give the players this. It is the whole handover on one page.

Item	Whose	Cost to use	What it does	The trap
Wraps of Unarmed Power +2	Stabby	none, always on	+2 to hit and damage on fists and feet; may deal Force	Does nothing for the katana
Wand of the War Mage +2	Ursa	none, but must be held	+2 on every spell attack; ignore Half Cover	Does not raise his save DC

Item	Whose	Cost to use	What it does	The trap
Wand of Web	Lilly	1 charge of 7, action	Web: 20-ft cube, Restrained on a failed save	Casts at DC 13 , not her 16
Ring of Spell Storing	Puff	free to use, but must be loaded first	Holds 5 levels; casts at the loader's DC and slot	Empty until somebody casts into it
Wand of Magic Missiles	Puff	1 to 3 charges of 7, action	3 darts that never miss (5 darts for 3 charges)	Puff gets one action, so one item per turn
Pipes of Haunting	Puff	1 charge of 3, Magic action	30 ft, Wis DC 15 or Frightened 1 minute	A creature that saves is immune for 24 hours

Recharging, once, for all of it: wands regain **1d6+1** charges at dawn, the pipes regain **1d3**. Not on a rest. At dawn. On a long rift run they may not see a dawn when they expect one, and Aelwyn does not know how time runs on the other side. Let that worry them a little.

This is where you hand out the new character sheets. The fiction and the paperwork happen in the same beat: Lilly gives them their gear, you give them their level 7.

7. The Briefing

Gather them at the ring. Aelwyn talks, Vane interrupts, and Lickgloom licks something it should not.

In plain words the kids can hold:

1. **The rifts are not doors somebody opened.** They are tears. Every strange thing they have fought for two years came through one.
2. **You cannot sew a tear from this side.** You go to the other side and take back what is bleeding out: the plane's **Mote**, the piece of its heart that is caught here.
3. **The Sphere is the anchor and the way home.** It gathers. Set it in the cradle and the ring opens; carry it through and it holds the way open behind them. **If the Sphere is lost over there, they do not come back.** Say that once, plainly, and never repeat it.
4. **Bring the Mote back and two things happen.** The tear closes, and the Sphere gets a little more of itself back. (*Lilly's tie-in: each Mote wakes one of the Sphere's sleeping discharges. Today all she can draw is the Aether Ward.*)
5. **Something living may come back with them.** Aelwyn is careful here, because he is guessing. Essence gathers toward warmth and company. (*Sandshrew setup; the payoff is the homecoming.*)

Read aloud. "I want you to understand that I am not sending you somewhere dangerous," Aelwyn says. "I am sending you somewhere indifferent. A plane is not hostile to you any more than a mountain is hostile to you. It simply does not care whether you can breathe there. Everything that hurts you on the other side will hurt you the way weather does."

Vane snorts. "That is a terrible speech."

"It is an honest one."

ART I: the briefing. Aelwyn mid-lecture at a chalkboard or an orrery, three small heroes listening, Vane with his arms folded, Ghostbloom at the edge and Puff on Lilly's shoulder. No assistant. Warm, crowded, human. The last quiet moment before the campaign changes.

7b. The Lesson: Underroot, and the Thing That Lives There

Aelwyn does this properly, with a chalkboard and far too much enthusiasm, because it is the first time in his life anybody has let him teach this to people who are actually going to go and look.

ART K: the lesson. Aelwyn at a chalkboard covered in a cross-section diagram of a plane and its anchor-star, one hand raised mid-explanation, the three children in front of him, Ghostbloom drifting at the edge. Warm, crowded, chalk dust in the light.

What the plane is

Read aloud. "Earth," says the professor, "is not a cave. I want that out of your heads immediately. You are not going underground. You are going to a place that is made of ground, all the way through, in every direction, forever."

He draws it: a world with no sky and no floor, only stone and soil and root going on and on.

"It is called Underroot. There is no sun there and it has never needed one. There are roots down there the size of cathedrals, and they are alive, and they are older than your species. The soil breathes, slowly, about once an hour. And nothing there is in a hurry, which will be the strangest part for you three."

Give the table these three practical facts, because they will matter in the second half:

1. **It is slow, not empty.** Things move on a geological schedule. A rockfall there is not an accident, it is a shrug.
2. **There is no sky, so there are no stars**, which means **Ursa cannot navigate**. Say this to his player directly. He has spent a year learning to read the ground; here that is the only sense that works.
3. **It is indifferent, not hostile.** Aelwyn's line from the briefing lands twice: the plane does not care whether they can breathe there.

What a Guardian is

This is the rule the rest of the campaign runs on, so teach it once, clearly, now.

Read aloud. "Every world keeps something. Not a king and not a god. A guardian: one creature, very old, that is somehow the shape of that world's health. When Gearhaven was sick, you found the Grand Custodian at the heart of it, twisted almost past recognition, and when you freed it the whole city knitted shut behind you. Do you remember?"

He taps the board.

"You did not do that by being clever. You did it by being kind to something that was hurting. I would like you to notice that, because you are about to do it again, and the thing you do it to this time is roughly the size of a hill."

The rule, in one line for the players: the corruption twists the guardian first, and freeing the guardian closes the cracks. They proved it on the Custodian in Session 7. This is the same move on a much larger scale.

The Guardian of Underroot

Aelwyn is honest that he is guessing here, because nobody has been.

Read aloud. "The Circle's oldest verses call it a continent-maker. They say Underroot's guardian is the reason there is dry land at all: that it walked, once, and the ground came up behind it. Whatever it is now, it has been sitting in a leaking wound for a very long time." He hesitates, which he almost never does. "I would prefer you not fight it."

"What if it fights us?" says Stabby, delighted.

"Then I would prefer you not lose."

DM notes. The Guardian of Underroot is **Groudon** (canon). Do not name it here; Aelwyn does not know the name. Let the party meet it in the second half as a shape in the dark and a sound in their teeth before it is ever a stat block. And note the deliberate echo: this is the same beat as the Grand Custodian, so the solution should feel available to them if they think back rather than being told again.

Ghostbloom

She has spent the year at the Guild with Vane and she has missed them, and she says so, at length, telepathically, to all three of them at once.

8. The Threshold

Last beats before the ring opens, in this order:

1. **Ursa looks up.** He has been reading the sky since he got back and he knows Antares is dimming. He does not say anything about it. *(He will be the only person at the table who understands what he is seeing when it relights at the end of the night. Do not spend that early.)*
2. **The idol goes cold again** in Stabby's pack, hard enough that he notices.
3. **Lilly sets the Sphere in the cradle.** It fits like it was cut for it.
4. **Vane does not make a speech.** He was going to. He has had ten years to write one. What he actually does is put a hand on Lilly's shoulder for a second and then go and stand at the lever, because he cannot manage anything else.

Read aloud. *The ring does not roar. That is the surprising part.*

The Sphere settles into the cradle with a small brass click, and the air inside the circle simply stops being air. What is on the other side is a red-brown dark, and warmth, and a smell like a garden turned over after rain, and a sound so low that you feel it in your teeth rather than hear it.

Somewhere on the far side of that opening, something the size of a hill breathes in.

Ghostbloom goes first, because of course she does.

ART J: the threshold. The opened ring seen from behind the party, three small silhouettes against a red-brown light, the dark beyond suggesting something enormous. This is the last image of Part One and it should make everyone want to come back from the break.

END OF PART ONE. Hand out sheets if you have not already. Break. Set up the Underroot board.

Art list for Part One

Tag	Scene	Status
A	The finished ring, Lilly alone at its foot	needed
B	Aelwyn arrives with Lickgloom	needed
C	Ursa at the eastern gate at dawn	needed
D	Stabby dropping from the rafters	needed
E	Lilly's year: the marks under the brass	needed
F	Stabby's year: the stillness test	done: stabby_the_stillness_test.png
G	Ursa's year: the empty camp at the shrine	needed
H	Ursa's year: the vision in the standing stones	needed
I	Aelwyn's briefing at the ring	needed
J	The threshold, the ring open onto Underroot	needed
-	The handover, gifts laid out	done: lilly_gifts_laid_out.png

Lilly Glimmergear: The Year of Questions

The Tale

She went home first.

That surprised everyone, including Lilly. She had spent two years climbing out of the Underdark, and the moment Gearhaven gave her a year to spend, she spent the first month of it walking back down. Deepforge Hollow smelled the way it always had, of hot metal and cold stone and the faint green tang of the lantern moss. Her mother was waiting at the door of the workshop with flour on her hands, because Poots Glimmergear had never in her life managed to do two things at once without ruining one of them.

Lilly put the Essence Sphere on the kitchen table and said: tell me everything.

What followed was the least satisfying conversation of her life. Her mother told her about the day she brought it home, about the long nights fitting the brass around it, about the sigil work along the equator that took eleven tries to get right. She talked like a craftsman describing a commission. And Lilly, who had grown up on her mother's stories and could recite most of them backward, noticed the shape of the hole in this one. Poots never once said where the thing inside the brass had come from.

So Lilly went looking.

She started at Glimmerspire, in the vaulted workshops where she had been the smallest apprentice in a hundred years. Master Drogen Sparkwick was older and slower and just as impossible to impress, and he made her earn every answer. She rebuilt three of her own childhood projects to his satisfaction before he would even look at the Sphere. When he finally did, he looked for a long time, and then he said something that stayed with her the whole year: *I taught your mother. I did not teach her this.*

After that she followed the trade roads. She sat at the benches of a dozen artificers, and she paid for their time in the only currency she had, which was work. She spent a season with a clockmaker in a hill town who could not cast a single spell and whose escapements were better than anything in Gearhaven. She spent six weeks with a woman who built prosthetic hands for miners and who taught Lilly more about how a thing should feel in a person's grip than any book had. She went back through Gearhaven twice and let Guildmaster Vane shout at her about tolerances until her ears rang, and she got better, and better, and then noticeably better, until the guild artificers stopped talking over her head and started asking what she thought.

That was the crafting. It filled her hands and it made her formidable. But it was not the year's real work.

The real work was the Sphere, and the Sphere would not answer.

She took it to wizards after that, which is a different animal entirely. Artificers ask what a thing does. Wizards ask what a thing *is*, and they are insufferable about it, and they were exactly what she needed. She showed it to a diviner who fainted. She showed it to a theorist who insisted it was a forgery and then wrote her four increasingly frantic letters over the following months. She learned to read three scripts she had no business reading. She filled a notebook, then another, then a third, and the third one was mostly crossings out.

The answer, when it came, was not in a library. It was in the brass.

She had taken the housing apart perhaps forty times that year, and on the forty first she stopped looking at her mother's beautiful sigil work and started looking underneath it. There were older marks under the brass. Not damage. Not tooling. Marks, deliberate and fine and utterly unlike any hand she had been trained to recognize, running along a surface that should have been the inside of a shell her mother made and was instead the outside of something else.

The brass was Glimmerspire. The brass was her mother, eleven tries and all.

The thing inside the brass was old. Not old like the Academy, which had stood four hundred years. Old like the mountain the Academy was cut into.

She sat on a workshop floor a very long way from home and understood, all at once, that her mother had not built the Essence Sphere. Her mother had found it, and recognized it for something, and spent a year of her own life building a house worthy of it. Poots Glimmergear, who could not do two things at once, had done the second best thing a person can do with a mystery: she had kept it safe and she had handed it on.

Lilly wrote to her that night. The letter was four pages and the first three were angry. She burned those and sent the fourth.

What She Learned

Here is the part that mattered, and Lilly worked it out herself, on that floor, with her notebook open and her hands still greasy.

She had spent her whole life trying to *build* her way to Pikachu. Better cannon, better dagger, better plating, better everything, as though the Sphere were a lock and cleverness were a key. It was never a lock. It is a **gatherer**. It was made, by someone, a very long time ago, to draw in loose planar essence and hold it. That is all it has ever done. It held Pikachu because Pikachu's spark was loose and the Sphere does not know the difference between a scrap of stray fire and the soul of somebody's friend.

You cannot pick a gatherer's lock. You can only give it something to gather.

So she stopped building at it and started listening to it. That is the whole of what she learned in a year, and it is the reason she came home different.

What She Brings Back

Aether Channeler. She can draw on the Sphere now, a little. Not command it: draw on it, the way you draw water from a well you did not dig. What she can pull out today is a shell of gathered motes, the **Aether Ward**, which wraps her and every friend within 30 feet in 2d8 + 5 temporary hit points. Twice, and then she needs a short rest before the Sphere will give again.

That is deliberately almost nothing compared to what the Sphere can do, and Lilly knows it. The five great discharges sleep in it: fire, water, air, earth, and shadow. Each one wakes only when that plane's Mote is brought back and set into the housing. Every rift the party closes hands her another piece of a weapon she is only beginning to understand. **The more planar energy the Sphere gathers, the more it will teach her.** For the first time in her life, Lilly's power grows by going *out* rather than by staying up all night at a bench.

Flash of Genius. A year of watching better crafters fail taught her the most useful thing an inventor can know, which is what failure looks like one second before it happens. When she or any friend within 30 feet is about to come up short, she can throw her whole considerable mind at the problem and add +5. Five times a day. It is not an invention. It is attention, which she now has in enormous quantities.

The workshop year. Her hands got good. Boomstick came out of that year, her mother's old repeating pistol rebuilt into something that is at once her weapon, her spell focus, and her arcane firearm. So did a small pile of gifts, which she laid out on the table the morning the three of them met again:

For	What	Why
Puff	Ring of Spell Storing	So her homunculus can carry a spell she has no hands left to cast.
Puff	Wand of Magic Missiles	Darts that never miss, for a companion who cannot roll well.
Puff	Pipes of Haunting	Because Puff is small and frightening things is a good trade.
Herself	Wand of Web	The battlefield control she never had.

For	What	Why
Stabby	Wraps of Unarmed Power +2	His fists were the only weapon he owned with no magic in them. She fixed that.
Ursa	Wand of the War Mage +2	Every spell he throws, and every star-arrow, lands truer.

She did not make any of it for herself first. That is worth noticing about her.

The Thread She Is Pulling

She came home with her mother's honesty restored and her mother's authorship gone. Somebody made the Essence Sphere. Somebody made it to gather planar essence, long before there was a crisis worth gathering it for, and then it sat in the dark until a gnome with flour on her hands picked it up.

Lilly does not know who. She has decided she is going to find out.

Stabby Sharpblade: The Year He Went Back

Part One: The Smallest Goblin in the Hollow

Every clan has one child who is a problem, and the Bloodfang had Stabby.

He could not do any of it. That is the part nobody outside the Hollow knows, because he has never once said it out loud. Goblin children learn the clan's arts from the time they can stand, and the arts simply did not take with him. Every stance slid off. Every drill went wrong in a way the instructors could not explain and eventually stopped trying to. He was not lazy and he was not stupid. He was *unteachable*, in a clan that had exactly one measure of a person's worth, and by the time he was five everyone had quietly agreed what he was going to be.

So he became the other thing. He became the joke. He was the loudest goblin in the Hollow, the one on the roof, the one who stole the chief's dinner on a dare and ate it in front of him. If they were going to laugh anyway he was going to decide what they laughed at, and he got extremely good at it, and it worked, in the way armor works.

And underneath it he taught himself to fight out of pure spite. Speed, cunning, and chaos, because those were the only three things nobody could take away from him. He beat a whole pack of rival goblins with a broken sword when he was small enough to hide in a barrel, and they gave him the name Sharpblade for it, and he still could not do a single one of the clan's forms.

Then he left. He told everyone it was for adventure. That was true and it was also the smaller half of the truth.

Skitch

Two years later, the party pulled a half-dead goblin courier out of the machinery under Gearhaven, and when Skitch could talk again the first thing he said was not thank you. It was a name. *Bloodfang*. The Hollow was in trouble. The Hollow had sent him a very long way to find the only Bloodfang anybody could name who had gone out into the world and come back alive from anything.

Stabby laughed at him. That is the honest version and it belongs in the telling. He laughed, because the clan asking for him was the clan that had spent his whole childhood explaining that he was not worth teaching.

Then he stopped laughing, packed in about four minutes, and went.

What was wrong

Bloodthorn Hollow had been going quiet for two years, and nobody there had a word for why.

It was not a war. Wars, the Bloodfang understood. This was a blight in the twisted woods, thin and patient, and it did not take the weak ones. It took the *strongest* first. The biggest hunter in the clan, then the second biggest, then down the list, and every goblin it took came back wrong or did not come back at all.

Understand what that did to them. The Bloodfang had one law, which was that the biggest goblin wins, and something in the woods was eating them in order, largest to smallest. By the time Stabby walked back in, the clan was mostly the small ones. The overlooked ones. The ones who had survived on speed and cunning and chaos, because nothing had ever considered them worth taking.

He knew every single one of them. He had been the smallest of them once.

He Does Not Go Back On His Word

This part he did the way he does everything, which is fast and loud and extremely well.

He spent eleven weeks hunting the things the blight had made out of his clansmen. He moved the whole Hollow twice, uphill and then across the water, over furious objection, because goblins hate moving and he was right. He set traps a cleverer person would not have thought of and a braver person would not have risked. By the end of the summer the Bloodfang were not dying anymore.

But he had not fixed it. He had only outrun it.

The blight had no body to put a sword through. It had a root somewhere under the twisted woods, and everything he killed grew back thinner and further out, and Candyfang went through the corrupted things the way a knife goes through smoke: it hurt them, and the wound closed. He could keep his clan alive like this for years, standing in front of them, never sleeping.

He was nine years old, and he understood with complete clarity that he was not enough and would have to go away and become enough.

He told the whole Hollow so, standing on a stump, at volume. He said he was going, he said he was coming back, and he said that when he did he would burn the thing in the woods out of the ground, root and all. Goblins do not make promises like that, because goblins who make promises like that die. Nokk says he did not even sound worried.

He has never once gone back on a thing he said out loud. Everyone who has ever met him knows that about him, and most of them think it is a joke.

The Fourth

Before he went, he asked Nokk a question he had been carrying since he was five.

Why could I never learn anything you people tried to teach me?

Nokk is old and half-blind and the last goblin alive who remembers the Hollow the way it was. She sat him down and told him the truth, which nobody had told him, because the ones who knew had agreed among themselves that it was kinder not to.

His father was the **Fourth**. The fourth leader the Bloodfang ever named, and by every account the best of them.

Nine years ago something came out of the deep woods. Nokk will not describe it well, because she was running at the time, and everyone who got a proper look at it is dead. What she knows is that the Fourth went out to meet it alone, and that he did not kill it, because it was not the kind of thing that can be killed.

He **sealed** it. He put it somewhere it could not get out of, and the only vessel to hand that night was his newborn son, and it cost him his life to do it.

The clan is named Bloodfang for that thing. Not for their own teeth. The **Red Fang** is older than the Hollow, and the Bloodfang have been the family that keeps it bound for longer than they have kept records, and every so often a bearer is born and the clan is supposed to know what to do about it.

They had forgotten what to do about it. That is the whole tragedy in one line.

And that is why the arts never took. There was something enormous asleep behind Stabby's ribs, pushing back against every form they tried to pour into him. He was never unteachable. He was *occupied*. Nine years of being the clan joke, and the reason was that his father loved the Hollow enough to hand his son the worst thing in the woods rather than let it loose on them.

Stabby did not say anything for a long time. Then he asked whether there was anyone left who could teach him to carry it.

Nokk told him the Bloodfang had a breathing form once, and that they had not invented it. It was taught to them, generations back, by people who came down out of the mountains with dark swords, *specifically so that a bearer could survive being one*. The clan let it die, because a goblin who spends two years learning to breathe loses every fight during those two years, and in a clan where the biggest wins nobody survives to finish.

She could not perform a single step of it. She remembered the count.

"Go and find whether they are real," she said. "And if they are, tell them the Hollow kept the count."

Part Two: The Mountain Where Nothing Moves

They are supposed to be a story.

Everyone has heard some version. A sect past the treeline on a mountain called Kettlecrown, where the sun arrives before it arrives anywhere else in the world. They forge swords from ore that drinks dawnlight. They spend their lives hunting what crawls in from outside the world, the corrupted and the rotted and the wrong. They do not take students, they do not come when called, and most sensible people file them somewhere between the tooth fairy and the goddess.

It took him two months to find the road and another nine days to climb it. And when he finally hauled himself over the last ledge, filthy and triumphant and ready to meet the greatest swordsmen in the world, what he found was bullywugs.

The Vigil

Frog-folk. The same wide-mouthed, damp, croaking people that every traveller's tale puts knee-deep in a swamp stealing boots. Except these ones were sitting on stone spires above the cloud line in the thin gold light, motionless, eyes half closed, doing absolutely nothing at all with tremendous authority.

And they were **enormous**. That is the thing nobody tells you about bullywugs, because almost nobody meets an old one: they never stop growing. A swamp bullywug dies young and stays the size of a person. Give one four hundred years of sitting still on a mountain and it ends up the size of a farm cart.

Stabby said a word here that has been left out of the record.

But think about it for one second longer than he did, because he came around to it eventually and so will the table. If you were going to build a school of **breathing** anywhere in the world, you would build it out of frog-folk. A bullywug is a bellows with legs. The whole body is a lung and a throat and a patient working set of muscles built for one long pull of air, and it can hold perfectly still for six hours on a warm rock and consider that time well spent.

The oldest of them is called **Grandmother Ottick**. She is roughly the size of a hay wagon, which tells you exactly how old she is, and she has been sitting on the same spire since before Bloodthorn Hollow had a name. The swords come off their forge lower down the mountain, where the young ones work the crimson ore, and the young ones are two hundred years old.

The Test Is Stillness

They did not care that he was a goblin. That surprised him, and it is worth landing at the table, because he had a whole speech ready. When you are four centuries old and the size of a hay wagon, a goblin and a human and an elf are all much the same thing: small, brief, and in a hurry.

They cared about one thing, and they knew it about him before he opened his mouth. The oldest of them looked at him for rather a long time and said, mildly, *you are carrying something*, and Stabby discovered that he had been braced his entire life for someone to say that and had no idea what to do when they finally did.

Then they tested him, and he failed badly.

They asked him to be still. Not to sit quietly, which he could have faked. To be *still*, entirely, from the inside, in the moment before violence. Every one of them could do it in their sleep, which is the entire problem with learning anything from a bullywug: they cannot explain how, because they have never once had to try. Grandmother Ottick's complete instruction, delivered over three months, was **stop wriggling**.

They put him on top of a spire to do it, on a flat stone no wider than a door, with a very long way down on every side and nothing to hold on to. Not as a punishment. Bullywugs consider this restful.

He could not do it for a breath. Not one. And this time he knew why, because he could feel the thing behind his ribs shift every time he tried to go quiet, the way a sleeping animal shifts when the room goes silent. Stillness is the one condition under which you can hear what is inside you, and Stabby had spent nine years being the loudest goblin alive precisely so that he would never have to.

He failed for eleven weeks. He nearly left twice.

The One Second

It broke in the third month, in the dark, with his lungs burning and his hands shaking, when he heard Master Kaelon Windstep say the thing he had said years ago that Stabby had never once managed to do.

When the whole world is screaming, little storm, get still.

He had always taken it as an instruction to calm down, which is why he ignored it, because he had no intention of calming down and never would. It was not that. It was smaller and far more useful. Kaelon had not asked him to become a calm person. He had asked him to be still **for one second**, at the one moment that mattered, before everything came apart.

One second, Stabby could do.

And in that one second, for the first time in his life, he got a good look at what he had been carrying. The Vigil's masters were ready for what happened next. Nobody was hurt. Afterward the oldest of them said the only thing anyone had ever said to Stabby that made the whole shape of his life click over into sense:

The breath is not a cage. Your father built the cage. The breath is a door, and you are the only one who gets to decide which way it opens.

Grandmother Ottick blinked at him once, slowly, which from a bullywug is a standing ovation.

The Blade

The Vigil forge their own steel and will not forge for anyone who has not lit their breath, which is why a Nichirin sword is a graduation and not a gift. Bullywugs, it turns out, are magnificent smiths. They are unhurried, the old ones are enormously strong, and damp skin does not flinch at a forge.

The ore came out of Kettlecrown's deep cut, crimson and strange, drinking the dawn the way dry ground drinks rain. He worked the bellows for eight days of it. What came off the anvil looked disappointing, and that is the point: sheathed and cold, a Nichirin blade is dark and plain and could be any sword in any village.

Then he ignited his breathing, and the steel caught it, and the whole length burned blood-red from guard to tip.

That is what the blade is *for*. It is not a magic sword he happens to own. It is a channel. Held still by the breath and poured out through sun-forged steel, the Red Fang's strength stops being a thing that eats him from the inside and becomes a thing that comes out of his hands at whatever he is pointing at.

They taught him **the basics and nothing more**, and they were honest about it. The form takes a lifetime and he had one winter, and there was a clan under a blight that could not wait for him to become a master.

They told him one more thing on the way down, which he has not repeated to anyone. The Vigil has been busier in the last five years than in the previous fifty. Whatever is tearing holes in the world is making a great deal of work for the people who clean up after it.

Part Three: Hero of the Hollow

He came down off Kettlecrown in deep winter and went home.

The Purge

The root of the blight was under the twisted woods and it had grown while he was gone, and this time he brought the right tool and the right lungs.

Cleansing Edge is not a metaphor. Corruption cannot heal from a Nichirin wound and cannot hide from the person holding one. He lit his breath, and the Fang's strength came up through him and out along the blade instead of tearing around inside him looking for a way out, and what had been eating his clan largest to smallest could not grow back the parts he cut away. He was patient about it in a way he has never been patient about anything.

It ended before spring.

Understand what that made him in that place. The Bloodfang had watched their biggest and best taken one after another for two years, and the thing that finally walked out of the twisted woods with the blight dead behind it was the runt. The clan joke. The one they had all quietly agreed was not worth teaching, who turned out to have been carrying their oldest enemy since the night he was born because his father chose the Hollow over his own life.

He came back for them when nobody in the world would have blamed him for staying gone. He kept a promise he had shouted off a stump. He burned the thing out of the ground, root and all, exactly as he said he would.

There is not a goblin in the Hollow who will hear a word against him now. He is their hero, in the plain and permanent way a clan decides such things, and it embarrasses him enormously.

The Thing That Actually Unlocked It

Here is what surprised him.

He came home a decent student of the first form and no more. What made him something else was **teaching it**.

He taught Nokk's count to every goblin left in the Hollow, which was nearly all of them, because the blight had taken the big ones and the small ones had inherited a clan. He taught it badly at first. To explain a thing you have to understand it, and to explain it to a room of impatient goblins you have to understand it completely, and somewhere in that winter, standing in front of forty clansmen clapping out an old woman's rhythm, Stabby stopped performing the form and started *having* it.

The Vigil gave him the basics. His clan gave him the rest, by making him say it out loud a hundred times until it was true.

Most of them will never finish it. Some will. And the next Bloodfang child born carrying something will not spend nine years being told they are unteachable, because there is a nine year old in the Hollow now who knows exactly what that feels like and has written the count down.

They Offered Him the Seat

Leader of the Bloodfang, at nine, the smallest goblin in the Hollow, by the only law they had ever recognized. His father's seat. The Fifth.

He said not yet.

Not no. He was careful about that, and Nokk noticed, and she is the only one who did. He turned it down because he was leaving in the spring and a leader who leaves is worse than none. But he did not say never, and when they pushed him he grinned at them with every tooth he owns and told them to hold it for him, because one day he is coming back to take it properly.

Then he gave them Candyfang. His candy-striped blade, the one Faelan gave him in the deep winter, the one he carried through every fight of his life until the Nichirin came. He put it in the Hollow's keeping and named it the clan's heirloom, and by their new law the heirloom is carried by whoever the clan would follow.

Which is why it is still on his belt. It is not his anymore. It is theirs, and he is only wearing it.

He left in the spring, made Gearhaven with ten minutes to spare, and he will tell you that was luck.

What He Learned

That he was never the joke, and never unteachable, and never too small. He was carrying something nobody had told him about, and the moment somebody finally did, the whole shape of his life turned out to have been a different story all along.

He is not calmer. Do not let anyone at the table think he came back calmer. He is exactly as much of a menace as he ever was. He has simply learned where to put the stillness, and one second turns out to be enough to change everything that happens after it.

A note for the DM. Stabby's player loves Naruto, so this is built on that shape on purpose: the overlooked class clown nobody will teach; a beast sealed inside him as a newborn by his own father, the clan's Fourth, who died doing it; the sealed power being the actual reason he could never learn what the other children learned; a public promise he refuses to break; training with a sect out of legend on a sacred mountain, who turn out to be enormous ancient bullywugs (played hard against type: the D&D frog-folk are usually swamp nuisances, and these are the world's foremost corruption-hunters), where the entire test is holding perfectly still on top of a rock spire and he is spectacularly bad at it; learning to channel the beast's strength rather than suppress it; coming home as the hero of the people who dismissed him; and being offered his father's seat and answering not yet, hold it for me. None of it is labelled and none of it needs to be. If he sees it he will grin. If he does not, it still reads as his own story.

Reveal pacing. The Fourth and the Red Fang are told to him by Nokk before he leaves, so his year has a reason. How much of it he has told **Lilly and Ursa** is the player's call, and "none of it yet" is a perfectly good answer that pays off later.

The Subclass: Warrior of Beast Breathing

He has set down the Way of the Kensei. Agile Parry and Kensei's Shot are gone. What replaces them is his own clan's lost form, taught to the Bloodfang generations ago by the Sunward Vigil for exactly one purpose: so that whoever carries the Red Fang can survive carrying it.

The idea behind it. Beast Breathing is not a rage, which is what everyone assumes. It is the opposite. You take everything hot and fast and screaming in you, and you hold it perfectly still, and only then do you let it out through the blade. All of the ferocity, none of the flailing. For Stabby that is not a metaphor about temperament. There is something behind his ribs and the breath is what decides which way the door opens.

What he gets

Igniting the Breath (*free, when he rolls initiative, 1 Focus*)

The one second, at the one moment it matters. His breath catches and burns until the fight ends. While it burns:

- every hit with the katana deals **+2 Force damage**
- his Speed increases by **10 feet** (45 on his own feet, 55 with the Sash, **65 ignited**)
- he has **advantage on Dexterity saving throws**

The blade takes the colour of the form, so the Nichirin burns blood-red while lit. Because Uncanny Metabolism refunds all his Focus when he rolls initiative once a day, turn one of the day's first fight costs him nothing.

First Form: Devour (*bonus action, 1 Focus; replaces Flurry of Blows*)

Move up to **15 feet without provoking**, then one katana strike for **3d8 + 9 Force** instead of normal damage. **If it drops the target he gets the Focus back**, so a Devour that finishes something is free and he can do it again next turn. The name is not decoration. This is the Fang's hunger, aimed on purpose.

Beast Sense (*passive*)

Advantage on Survival to track, on Perception using smell or hearing, and on **Intimidation**. He is a scout now, which he was not before, and he is unexpectedly frightening.

Monk Weapon (*passive*)

The katana counts as a Monk weapon for him, so his Martial Arts die applies and he keeps his bonus-action unarmed strike. With Lilly's wraps that punch is +10 for 1d8+7 and can deal Force.

How his turn actually runs

- **Initiative:** ignite the breath. Uncanny Metabolism refills Focus to 7 and heals him. Speed is 65.
- **Action:** two katana swings at +10 for **1d10+7** each, plus 2 Force apiece while lit. Stunning Strike on the first hit against something dangerous.
- **Bonus action: First Form: Devour**, a third strike at 3d8+9 Force with 15 feet of free movement in front of it. Or just punch, at +10 for 1d8+7.
- **Reaction:** Deflect Attacks, reducing a hit by **1d10+12** and throwing it back if it reaches zero.
- **New at 7: Evasion.** When something explodes near him he takes nothing on a success and half on a failure.

Why this build matters from here on

Cleansing Edge. Once a turn, when he hits a fiend, an undead, a shadow creature, or anything empowered by planar corruption, that creature **cannot regain hit points** and **cannot hide from him in darkness** until his next turn.

Everything that comes through a rift is on that list. He did not pick the subclass that hits hardest. He picked the one built for the specific enemy this campaign has been pointing at since Session 1, and he picked it because a mountain full of very old frog-folk who have spent centuries cleaning up planar corruption looked at a nine year old goblin and recognised what he was carrying.

The Thread He Is Pulling

The idol was in his pack the whole year. Up Kettlecrown and back down again.

He never showed it to the Vigil, which is strange, because the Vigil are the world's foremost experts on exactly the sort of thing it probably is, and he had months of evenings in which to mention it. He never showed it to Nokk either. It sat at the bottom of his bag through every month of the count, cold the way it has been cold since the day it appeared there after Wraithpine and nobody would admit to putting it there.

Twice that winter he woke up holding it. He does not remember getting it out.

He has decided this is not worth mentioning to anyone, which is the single most Stabby decision he made all year.

Ursa Catchum: The Road East

Part One: What Elder Selarin Would Not Give Him

The other two went home. Ursa went the other way.

He walked back into the Circle of the Eternal Stars for exactly nine days, which was long enough to do one thing, and the one thing was to ask Elder Selarin for his father's papers.

Selarin said no.

It is worth understanding why, because Selarin is not a villain and the scene plays better if the table can feel both sides of it. He raised Ursa. He was there the morning Ash Catchum walked east and did not come back, and he has spent the years since watching a boy grow up in the shape of that absence. Ash's field notes are in a locked cabinet in Selarin's own quarters, and they have been for years, and the reason is simple: they are the notes of a man who followed a thing that swallows sky-readers, and they are extremely persuasive.

"You are eight," Selarin said.

"I know how old I am," said Ursa.

They argued for nine days. On the ninth, Selarin unlocked the cabinet, because he had known from the first hour that he was going to and had been buying time to make his peace with it. He handed the whole bundle over without a word, and then he said one thing, which Ursa has repeated to nobody:

Your father read the sky better than any of us. It did not save him. Read the ground too.

Illustration slot. *Selarin at the cabinet, the bundle of notes held out, the boy's hands already reaching. Firelight, night through the window, one bright star.*

What was in the bundle

Not a map. That is the first disappointment and it is important.

Ash Catchum's notes are the working papers of a man in the middle of a thought: sky charts with dates, columns of numbers, the same constellation drawn eleven times over eleven months with one point of light getting fainter each time. Pages of shorthand nobody else could read. Sketches in the margins, some of them beautiful, most of them of things Ursa could not identify.

And running through all of it, underlined twice and never explained, one word: **Betelgeuse**.

The first star to go out. The one his father was chasing.

The notes stop in the middle of a page. Not at the end of a thought. In the middle of one.

Part Two: The Skyless Country

He went east on foot and alone.

That is the part the other two did not have and it should sit heavy in the telling. Lilly spent her year in workshops full of people. Stabby spent his surrounded by an entire clan who came to worship him. Ghostbloom stayed behind at the Guild with Vane, because where Ursa was going had no roads and he would not risk her.

So it was a boy of eight, a staff, a fur cloak, and eleven months of walking.

The first four months were ordinary, and the table should hear that, because the ordinariness is what makes the rest land. He worked for meals. He slept in barns and under hedges and once, memorably, in a hollow tree with a badger who did not want him there and, thanks to the Mark, eventually got over it. He got very good at being alone. He got very good at asking old people questions, because old people remember the direction a stranger walked off in twenty years ago.

Then the maps ran out.

The Skyless Country is what the last people out that way call it, and they say it the way you say the name of a bad neighbour. It is not a wasteland. It is worse than that, in a quiet way: it is perfectly ordinary land, hills and streams and thin woods, under a sky that is *wrong*. Cloud that never breaks. Not storm cloud. A low grey lid, day after day, week after week.

For a druid who navigates by constellations, it is a blindfold.

He lost eleven days in there. He will not talk about the eleven days.

***Illustration slot.** Small figure with a staff on an empty grey hillside, enormous flat sky, no stars, no horizon line worth speaking of. The loneliest picture in the book.*

The cairns

What saved him was that his father had been there first.

Six days after he stopped being able to navigate, wet through and rationing badly and frightened in a way he had not admitted to himself yet, Ursa came over a rise and found a pile of stones. Just a cairn, waist high, the kind any traveller might leave. Except the top stone had a mark scratched on it, and the mark was a seven-pointed star wrapped in a leafed vine, and Ursa had been looking at that sigil on Elaria's gifts since he was six years old.

His father had built a road of them. Not a path on the ground. A line of cairns across a country where you cannot see the sky, each one placed exactly at the edge of sight of the last, so that a person could cross the blind land one stone at a time.

Ash had built it going out. Ursa walked it going in.

It took him five weeks and he did not lose the line once. He also, and this is the detail that undoes people, **repaired eleven of them**, because a few had fallen and there was no reason to assume he would be the last person to need the road.

The omens begin

Somewhere in the Skyless Country, Ursa started dreaming numbers.

He would wake with two of them in his head, clean and certain and meaning nothing, and then at some point in the day he would need exactly one of them, and the moment would arrive with the number already sitting in his hand like a stone he had picked up hours ago.

He thought he was going mad for about a fortnight. Then he started writing them down on waking, and found he was right every time, and stopped thinking he was going mad and started being quietly and profoundly frightened instead.

His father was a sky-reader. Under a sky he could not read, something else had started reading *for* him.

Part Three: The Shrine

He came out of the Skyless Country into clear air and old forest, and eight days later he found the place.

The old shrine, far east beyond the maps. Older than the Circle. Older, probably, than anything with a name in it. A ring of standing stones half swallowed by a glade, every one of them carved with the same seven-pointed star, worn nearly smooth by a great deal of weather and a great deal of time.

And in the middle of it, a camp.

***Illustration slot.** The glade at dusk. Standing stones, moss, low slanted light. A long-cold firepit in the middle with a stone shelf beside it. Nobody in the picture. This one should hurt a little.*

What he found

Nobody. Ursa did not find his father. That is the first thing to say plainly at the table, because the players will hope, and the hope is the point.

He found the camp his father made, and he found it in the condition of a place somebody meant to come back to.

A firepit lined with stones. A shelter of bent living branches, still holding, because a druid built it and asked the tree nicely. A stack of split wood under a stone overhang, dry, ready. A tin cup. A worn place on a flat rock exactly the shape of somebody who sat there most evenings for a long time.

Nothing was packed. Nothing was buried. Nobody had said goodbye to this place.

And on the stone shelf beside the firepit, in a small worn hollow where something round used to sit, there was nothing at all.

How long ago

Here is the thing that changed Ursa's whole year, and it is a small thing, and he found it by doing exactly what Selarin told him to do.

Read the ground too.

The bent-branch shelter was still alive. Growing. A shelter like that is coaxed out of a living tree, and the tree keeps growing afterward, and the wood had closed around the bindings by an amount that Ursa, who has been a druid since he could walk and knows precisely how fast a young ash tree closes over a rope, could read like a page.

Not fifteen years.

Three.

Ursa's father walked east and vanished when Ursa was a baby. Everyone the boy has ever met has spoken about Ash Catchum in the past tense for his entire life. And Ash Catchum sat in this glade, on that flat rock, splitting that firewood, **three years ago**.

He was alive far, far more recently than anybody believed.

Ursa sat down in the middle of the standing stones and cried for a while, which he has not mentioned to Lilly or Stabby, and then he got up and got to work, because he is his father's son and that is apparently what they do.

The stone

He found it under the flat rock, wrapped in oilcloth, put there on purpose by someone who wanted it to survive the weather.

A river stone, smooth as an egg, dark grey. On one face, carved carefully and well, the seven-pointed star of Elaria wrapped in its leafed vine.

Half of it.

The line stops. Not broken, not worn: *stopped*, mid-stroke, the way a pen stops when someone speaks your name. Ursa knows his father's hand from a bundle of notes he had read forty times by then, and this is his father's hand, and his father put the chisel down in the middle of a line and wrapped the stone and hid it under a rock and did not come back to finish it.

When Ursa closed his hand around it, the stone was warm.

It has been warm ever since.

Illustration slot. Close on his hands, the half-carved stone, the unfinished line. Faint gold in the groove. No face, no background: just the object and the boy's hands.

The night the sky came back

He stayed at the shrine eleven days, and on the eighth the cloud broke for the first time since the Skyless Country, and Ursa Catchum lay down flat on his back in the middle of a ring of ancient stones and looked up at a sky he had not seen properly in four months.

He knew immediately that something was wrong with it.

There was a hole in the sky. Not a rift: a **gap**, a place in a constellation he had known since he was small where a star was simply not, and had not been for a long time, and the dark around it had a shape.

Betelgeuse. The one in his father's notes, underlined twice.

He had grown up hearing that the stars were going out. He had heard it the way children hear that a war happened somewhere before they were born. Lying on his back at the shrine, eight years old, a very long way from anyone who loved him, he *looked at the missing one*, and it stopped being a story.

That is the night the staff woke up.

The vision

He did not fall asleep so much as get taken.

The standing stones lit from the inside, all of them at once, the seven-pointed star burning in the rock like a coal under ash. And a voice that Ursa had heard exactly once before, at a glade a very long way west when he was six years old and the whole world was still simple, said his name.

Elaria showed him three things.

The first was his father, walking. Not fleeing, not falling: *walking*, deliberately, toward a light that was going out. The vision would not show his face and Ursa understood without being told that this was on purpose. What it showed him instead was the intent, and the intent was this: **Ash Catchum went east to save the stars.** Not for glory and not for a discovery. He went because the lights were failing and somebody had to go and see why, and he was the best sky-reader alive, and so it fell to him.

Ursa has carried, since he was old enough to understand the word *disappeared*, a small ugly question he never once said out loud: *did my father choose to leave me?*

The answer is yes. And the reason is the best reason there has ever been.

The second was the thing behind it. A wall at the bottom of everything, and behind the wall a hunger with patience, pressing. He knew the name before the vision gave it to him, because he has been hearing it in the Circle's old verses since he was small.

Maldrith. The Weaver of Fractures. Sealed beyond the last wall when Elaria spent herself, and pressing on it ever since, and the stars are going out because she is winning.

The third was a shadow that walks for her. A figure in black on a high place with the sky dying behind it, putting out a light with its hand as calmly as a person pinching a candle. And the vision gave that one a name too, the way you hand somebody a weapon.

Nyxthid. The Harbinger of Decay.

Ursa came off that shrine floor with his heart going like a bird and one clean thought in his head, and it was not grief and it was not fear. It was a *task*. His father went to save the stars. Something is putting them out. It has a name, and now he has the name.

He said it out loud, alone, in a ring of standing stones, eight years old, and swore at the top of his lungs that he was going to find it.

DM notes, critical. This is the *FIRST* time the name Nyxthid is spoken in the campaign; verified against every session document. Maldrith the players already know, from the Lore of Elaria boxes in Sessions 2, 3 and 4, so that name lands as a connection snapping shut rather than as exposition.

Nyxthid is Ash. Ursa has just sworn to hunt his own father and will spend four sessions doing it. Elaria did not lie to him: every single thing she showed him is true. She simply did not show him that the man walking east and the shadow in black are the same person, because he was eight years old and alone and about to walk home across a country with no sky, and she needed him to survive the trip.

Keep the figure featureless. No face, no height, no build, nothing Ursa could match later. If a player asks what it looked like, it looked like a hole in the shape of a person.

What He Learned

That his father was not lost. His father was **interrupted**.

Those are entirely different things and Ursa has built the rest of his life on the difference. A lost man is a tragedy you learn to carry. An interrupted man is a sentence somebody stopped in the middle, and Ursa has read enough of his father's handwriting now to know that Ash Catchum does not leave sentences unfinished by choice.

And the second thing, which is quieter and which the table will feel later: he came home able to see about one second further ahead than anyone else, and he did not earn that on purpose. It came to him in a country with no sky, from a direction he cannot name, and he is not entirely sure it is a gift, and he has decided to use it anyway.

What He Brings Back

Reader of Omens. After a long rest he wakes with **two d20s** already rolled, written down before the day starts, his to spend on any roll he or anyone he can see makes. He carries **both Weal and Woe** every day now instead of one or the other, and he can wait until **after the die has landed** before deciding which to apply. Five uses from a single pool, and his tides run deeper than an ordinary star-reader's: **1d6 + 2** either way.

The Awakened Gifts. Kneeling at his father's shrine woke the things he was already carrying. The **Staff of Waking Constellations** became a +2, its **Starseed** grew from 1d4 to **1d8**, and the **Amulet of Guiding Light** now reaches **every ally within 30 feet** instead of only those standing in its glow.

Ash's Sigil-Stone. Warm since the day he picked it up. It gives him **Aura of Vitality** once a day without a slot, and it holds **two charges** he can spend to **Ask the Day**, **Glimpse the Trail**, or **Read the Heart**. It is his father's unfinished work and he does not let anyone else hold it.

Elemental Fury, from the year of practice: +5 to the damage of any of his cantrips.

What he does not bring back: his father. Say that out loud once. He has been walking for a year and he is closer than he was, and he does not have him.

The Thread He Is Pulling

Three years. Not fifteen.

Somewhere between this shrine and now, three years ago, a wildfire druid stood up from a flat rock in a ring of standing stones, put down a half-finished carving, and went to do something he expected to come back from.

Ursa is going to find out what. He has a name for the thing that took his father from him, and he has said out loud that he is going to find it, and he does not go back on a thing he has said out loud either. That runs in the family.

DM notes, do not read aloud.

The Session 12 clue is planted twice and Ursa notices neither. There is a small worn hollow in the stone shelf where something round used to sit and is now gone. And Ash's field notes are full of sketches of a small creature that Ursa, who has never seen it, cannot identify. Both are Pikachu. Ash had him. Do not let anyone roll to work this out, and do not have Lilly's player recognise the sketches: the payoff is Session 12, when Pikachu is revealed as Ash's.

Antares. Ursa saw the gap where Betelgeuse used to be. He has not yet noticed that Antares, the Earth star, is dimming. When it relights at the end of this session, he will be the only person at the table who understands what he is looking at, and that is his moment. Save it.

The cairns are reusable. Ash built a road of marked stones across a country where you cannot navigate. If the campaign ever needs Ursa to find something unfindable again, the road is already in the fiction, and he repaired eleven of them on his way in.

Session 8, Part Two: Underroot

The rift run. Board: assets/session_08/underroot_board.png.

How the board works

The party moves as **one token**. On their turn a player rolls **1d6** and moves that many spaces, and whoever is holding the token rotates each roll so every kid gets to move it.

They land on a colour and it resolves. **Read the die they just moved with: EVEN or ODD picks which of the two outcomes happens.** No tables to look up, no second roll.

Dot	Colour	Even	Odd
Move	slate blue	Nothing. Keep going.	Nothing. Keep going.
Encounter	garnet	Thumpaw	The Gleamoth
Boon	moss	The Deepwater Spring	The Shortcut
Hazard	ochre	Sinkloam	The Ceiling Lets Go
Wild	amethyst, !	The Reef Answers	The Guardian's Dream

All eight are written out in *The Road Between*, below.

The four numbered locations are not dots. They are fixed story stops: the token stops at each one regardless of movement remaining, the beat plays, and movement resumes next turn. **The Rift Gate is the arrival and has no fight.**

One rule above all the others: they came here to fight

The kids come to this table to fight things. Objectives, levers and clever plays exist to make the fighting *better*, and they must never be an off-ramp that skips it. Nothing in this session can be talked down, waited out, or avoided. The levers below all do the same thing: they turn a grinding fight into a satisfying one, and finding them is the reward.

The creature roster

Ten creatures, and **every scripted fight uses two types** so no encounter is a single wall of the same thing.

Fight	Bruiser	Pressure
1. Mosslight Landing	Rotblooms (re-bloom until burned)	Mossmites (fast, weak, swarm)
2. Chime Reef	Chimestones (armoured, stun on thunder)	Shardwings (flying, dive, ranged)
3. Glassed Gallery	Glass Weeper (regenerates)	Cinderolls (roll in and detonate)
4. Groudon's Hollow	GROUDON (the spike)	Glasslings (spawned BY the spike)

Random encounters only: Thumpaw and the **Gleamoth swarm**. These two never appear at a scripted fight and are the only creatures the party meets purely by luck, which makes a garnet dot feel different from a story beat instead of feeling like filler.

Glasslings matter mechanically. The spike spawns one at the start of each of Groudon's turns. That is the pressure that stops the party from ignoring the spike and plinking Groudon: the longer the spike lives, the more little glass things are chewing on them. Break it and every remaining Glassling collapses instantly, which is a fantastic moment.

Four fights, and where they fall

The shape of the evening is fixed, and the dots are pacing between the fixed points:

#	Where	Who	Difficulty	Purpose
1	Mosslight Landing	6 Rotblooms + 6 Mossmites	warm-up, but it runs long	Teaches the rule: corruption re-blooms unless Stabby burns it.
2	Chime Reef	3 Chimestones + 3 Shardwings	hard , or easy if they use thunder	The fight with a lever in it.
		SHORT REST		Immediately after the reef. Call it out loud: Hit Dice spent, Stabby's Focus back, Ursa's Wild Shape back, Lilly's Aether Ward back.
3	The Glassed Gallery	Glass Weeper + 4 Cinderolls	hardest before the boss	Stabby's proving ground.
4	Groudon's Hollow	Groudon + Glasslings	boss, but see The Spike	The rescue.

***A note on the numbers.** Fights 2 and 3 are deliberately above a "deadly" budget on paper, and both have a lever that collapses them: **thunder stuns a Chimestone and doubles all damage against it, and tending the roots strips the Weeper's regeneration.** A party that finds the lever wins comfortably. A party that ignores it is in a real fight. That gap is the fun, so do not soften either one before the players have had a chance to be clever.*

A garnet Encounter dot between these is **small pressure**, two or three weak things that cost a little resource and no more. Do not let a dot roll become a fifth big fight; the four scripted ones are the session.

Pace check. There are 22 dots between the gate and the Hollow. If the evening is running long, hand-wave the dots between locations 3 and 4 and go straight to Groudon. The four story stops are the session; the dots are texture.

The Descent

1. The Rift Gate: the first breath

Read aloud. *You expected a cave.*

What you are standing in is a root. One root, arching over you like the ceiling of a cathedral, running away into the dark in both directions further than your light reaches. The ground under your boots is warm, and soft, and it is breathing: a slow swell and settle, about once every minute, so gentle you would miss it if you were not standing still. There is no sky. There is no sun. There is light, though, a low green-gold glow coming off the moss in patches, enough to see by, and the air smells like a garden turned over after rain.

Behind you the ring hangs in the air, a bright coin of Gearhaven lamplight, and Vane's shape is standing in it with his arms folded, getting smaller.

Beats to land here:

- **The Sphere is warm** in Lilly's hands, and it is *pulling*. She can feel it gathering. It has never done that before and it does not stop for the rest of the session.
- **Ursa cannot navigate.** Say it to his player directly. No sky, no stars, and his year of star-reading buys him nothing. What does work is what Selarin told him: read the ground. Give him advantage on Survival down here for reading root growth and soil.

- **Stabby's idol is cold.** Colder than it was in the Rift Hall. He will keep checking it all session and it will keep getting worse.
- **Ghostbloom is delighted.** She is a plant-spirit standing inside a plane made of growing things and she has never been so happy. Let her player-facing chime be joy, all session, right up until the Hollow.

No encounter. They get one safe scene to be amazed. Do not spend it.

2. Mosslight Landing: the friendly face

Board location 1.

Read aloud. *The root opens into a hollow the size of a village, and it is beautiful. Round mossy mounds swell out of the floor with little round doors of packed earth, though nobody built them and nobody lives in them: that is simply the shape moss grows in here. Threads of pale gold light drift up from the ground like slow sparks going the wrong way. Something is watching you from the top of the nearest mound. It is about the size of a badger, armoured in overlapping plates of yellow-brown hide, with small dark eyes and enormous digging claws, and it is absolutely rigid with the effort of not being seen.*

This is the Sandshrew, and this is the only time the party meets it in the flesh before the homecoming. **It cannot be caught, tamed, or bagged.** It watches them. If they are kind or feed it, it follows at a distance for the rest of the run and is present at the end. If they are aggressive, it vanishes and joins them at the homecoming anyway, which will feel like a gift they did not earn.

Ursa's Mark of Handling works on it and should be the moment his player realises the plane's wildlife is not the enemy.

Encounter 1: the Rotblooms

The pretty part of Underroot has a wound in it. On the far mounds the moss is **grey and wet and wrong**, and standing in it, swaying, are six little flower-creatures.

They were lovely a month ago. You can still see it: round soft bodies, stubby arms, big round flower-caps that used to be gold. The caps are grey now, and slack, and they leak. When they notice the party they all turn at once, and their faces are still smiling, because their faces cannot do anything else.

6 Rotblooms and 6 Mossmites (statblocks below). The Mossmites boil out of the moss the moment the first Rotbloom is struck: tiny, fast, six-legged, one enormous eye each, individually harmless and collectively a nuisance that keeps everyone honest while the real problem re-blooms behind them.

Read aloud. *Ghostbloom makes a sound you have never heard her make. She knows what these are. They are almost the same as her.*

- **Design intent: this fight exists to hand Stabby the session.** Rotblooms re-bloom every round and ordinary weapons cannot finish them: cut one down and it swells back up out of its own cap. **Cleansing Edge is the answer** and it is the only one the party has. Let them flail for a round, let Lilly and Ursa watch their damage undo itself, then let Stabby ignite and cut one and have it *stay* cut.
- **Six of them, and they hit in a cloud.** This is a proper scrap, not a speed bump: Spore Puff means the whole party is making saves, Puff and Ghostbloom are in the mix, and everyone gets three or four rounds of swinging.
- **Say it out loud when it lands:** he spent a year on a mountain learning to burn corruption out of the ground, and this is the first time anyone else has seen it work. His player has been carrying that backstory alone since the reading. Give him the beat.

- **The tell:** they do not attack the Sandshrew, and it does not run from them. It hides from the *party*. Corruption does not eat its own.

3. Chime Reef: the beautiful trap

Board location 2.

Read aloud. *The tunnel opens and you all stop at once, because the sound arrives before the sight does.*

Crystals. Thousands of them, growing up out of a shallow black pool in spires and fans and thickets, blue and gold and green, some of them taller than Vane's workshop. And the whole reef is ringing, very quietly, a slow shifting chord you feel in your back teeth. When the ground breathes, the note changes.

Ghostbloom makes a sound none of you have heard her make before. Ursa, without deciding to, has taken his hand off his staff.

Beats:

- **The reef answers sound.** Anything loud makes the crystals ring louder, and a big enough noise brings a spire down. Reward players who work this out and use it.
- **Lilly can read the growth pattern** with an Arcana check: the crystals are growing *toward* something deeper in, the way plants grow toward light. Whatever is down there, the whole reef is leaning on it. (It is Groudon.)
- **A quiet gift.** If anyone spends a turn just listening, Elaria's presence is faintly here, in the chord. Ursa's player may notice it is the same seven-note shape as the Havenmoor bells.

Encounter 2: the Chimestones

Four boulders in the shallows unfold legs and stand up.

They are squat and heavy and armoured in deep blue-black rock, with blunt jaws and small bright amber eyes, and jagged orange crystals growing out of their backs and shoulders like a struck chord frozen in place. They are **not corrupted**. They are the reef's immune system, and the party is loud and warm and came in through a hole.

3 Chimestones and 3 Shardwings (statblocks below). The Chimestones are the wall. The Shardwings are the reason nobody gets to stand still: pale crystal darts the size of hawks that dive, spit shards from sixty feet, and are almost impossible to pin down. They are also **vulnerable to thunder**, so the same lever works on the whole encounter.

- **This is a real fight and they are tough.** AC 16, they hit hard, and they resonate: every round the whole reef rings louder and everybody's ears hurt.
- **The clever play does not end the fight, it wins it.** Thunder damage makes a Chimestone ring itself apart: any thunder damage **stuns it until the end of its next turn**, and it takes **double damage** while stunned. Lilly's Thunderwave and Shatter, Stabby's Nichirin against the crystal, and Ursa's Thunderwave all turn one of these from a wall into a free kill.
- **The reef itself is a weapon.** Anyone can spend an action to strike a big crystal spire (DC 13 Athletics): the note rolls out and **every Chimestone in 30 ft. must save or be stunned**. Reward the player who thinks of it. Let them bring the roof down on the last one if they earn it.
- **The trade-off that keeps it honest:** the ringing hurts the party too. Anyone who uses the spire trick takes 1d6 thunder themselves. Nobody minds.

4. The Glassed Gallery: the wound

Board location 3.

Read aloud. *You know something is wrong a hundred feet before you reach it, because the ground stops breathing. Ahead of you the roots are **black glass**. Not burned: glassed, smooth and shining and hard, frozen mid-growth in the middle of reaching for something. The whole gallery is silent in a way nothing else down here has been. There is no moss light. Your own lamps look small.*

And every surface, when you get close, is covered in fine cracks that are very slowly, very quietly, spreading.

This is what the rift is doing to Underroot, and the party should feel the size of it. This is not a monster's lair. It is a burn scar going outward at the speed of grass growing, and it has been going for two years.

Beats:

- **The idol is now painfully cold.** Stabby has to wrap it in cloth to carry it. It has never behaved like this. *(Do not explain. Door C seed.)*
- **Lilly's Sphere is drinking.** It is visibly brighter here, and it is gathering fastest where the damage is worst. She can work out that the loose essence bleeding out of this wound is exactly what her Sphere was built to collect.
- **The dead giveaway:** the cracks all radiate outward from one direction. Deeper in. Toward the Hollow.

Encounter 3: the Glass Weeper and the Cinderolls

Something is still standing in the gallery.

It was one of the big slow root-tenders once: a long-necked creature that anchored itself in the soil and swayed, with a crown of soft fronds it used to comb the roots clean. The corruption caught it mid-stride and turned all of it to black glass, fronds and all, and it is **still trying to do its job**, sweeping shattered glass fronds through glassed roots that cannot feel it.

Around its feet, rolling in fast, are lumps of black glassy coal the size of footballs, each with one furious orange eye.

1 Glass Weeper + 4 Cinderolls (statblocks below), the Cinderolls arriving **two at a time** so the pressure never stops but never quite swamps them.

- **This is the big fight of the run before the boss, and it should be hard.** The Weeper hits for real, it regenerates 10 a round, and the Cinderolls keep rolling in and detonating.
- **The clever play strips its armour instead of ending the fight.** The Weeper is bound to the glassed roots it is tending. Any character who spends an action clearing or healing the roots nearby (DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing spell aimed at the roots) makes the Weeper **lose its regeneration for one round** and gives everyone **advantage on attacks against it until the start of their next turn**. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard. It never ends the encounter: it makes the party feel brilliant while they finish it.
- **This is Stabby's proving ground.** The Weeper regenerates 10 a round and the party cannot out-damage it. Only radiant, force, or **Cleansing Edge** shuts that off, and Stabby is the reliable source. He is the reason this fight is winnable and everyone at the table should be able to see it.
- **The gallery itself is his too.** After the fight, if he walks the glassed roots with his breath lit, the corruption recoils from the Nichirin exactly as the blight did at home. He cannot heal the gallery, it is far too big, but he can burn a clean path through it, and the party walks out of the wound on a road he made. That image is the whole point of his year.
- **When it falls** it shatters, and inside the glass, curled up where the heart would be, is a small ordinary creature that has been dead for two years. That is the moment the session turns from an adventure into a rescue, and it is the last beat before Groudon.

5. Groudon's Hollow: the Guardian

Board location 4. The boss.

Read aloud. *The tunnel ends and there is no floor, only a drop into a chamber so large your light does not find the far side of it.*

Something down there is breathing. You have been feeling it since you arrived, the slow swell of the ground every minute or so, and now you understand what you have been standing on top of all day. It was never the plane breathing.

*It was **him**.*

*He fills the hollow: a mountain with a spine, red-brown plates the size of barn doors, claws sunk deep into stone he has not moved from in a very long time. Glowing seams of magma run down his flanks like veins. And driven into his back, up near the shoulder where he cannot possibly reach it, is a **spike of black glass**, and the cracks in the world spread out from that one point.*

He is the reason there is dry land anywhere. And he is in agony, and he has been for two years, and he has not been able to say so.

The fight, and what it is actually about

Groudon is not the villain. The spike is. The Grand Custodian rule applies exactly: *free the guardian and the cracks close.*

- **Do not let the party win by damage.** Groudon has more hit points than they can chew through and hits hard enough to drop a level-7 hero in two turns. If they simply brawl, they lose.
- **The win condition is the spike.** It is a hard target on his back: reachable by climbing (Athletics/Acrobatics), by flight (Stabby's Sash, Ursa's Starry Form), or by a called shot at range with disadvantage. It has **AC 17 and 60 hit points**, and it is **immune to everything except radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**.
- **When the spike breaks, the fight ends instantly.** Not "he has 40 HP left." It ends.

The Glasslings

The spike creates one Glassling at the start of each of Groudon's turns: a cat-sized scuttling thing of black glass that drops off his back and goes for the nearest warm body. They are weak, they explode when killed, and they never stop coming.

They exist to answer the obvious question, which is *why not just ignore the spike and plink the big guy?* Because the longer the spike lives, the more of these are chewing on the party. **When the spike breaks, every Glassling on the field collapses into sand at once**, and that is a genuinely great moment: the whole board clears in a heartbeat.

This is the shape of the encounter: survive a very large angry mountain long enough for somebody to get up his back and break the thing hurting him. Every character has a role and each should get their moment:

- **Stabby is the one who ends this, and the whole session has been building to it.** Speed 65 ignited, Step of the Wind to close, and the Nichirin is one of only three things in the world that can touch the spike. He climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and he cuts the corruption out of a god. **This is his moment. Do not let anybody else take it unless his player hands it over.** If the dice go badly, let Ursa's summon pin Groudon or Lilly's Flash of Genius rescue the climb check, so the last blow is still his.
- **Ursa** keeps everyone alive and can put a summon between Groudon and whoever is climbing. His Mark of Handling lets him *feel* that the creature is in pain, which nobody else can, and telling the others is the moment the fight becomes a rescue.
- **Lilly** shoots the spike from range and holds the party together with Aether Ward. Force damage from Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles works on the spike and never misses.

Groudon's turns

Full statblock below. He is played as **a natural disaster with a wounded animal inside it**, not a tactician. Alternate:

1. **Continental Step:** he moves. The floor changes. Everyone makes a Dexterity save or is knocked prone and takes falling rubble damage.

2. **Magma Vent:** a line or cone of superheated stone.

3. **Claw and Slam:** if anything is in reach.

4. **Thrash (when the spike is damaged):** he screams and everything on him must hold on.

Mercy rule for the table: if a hero drops, Groudon does not finish them. He does not know they are there in any meaningful way. He is swatting at pain.

The Road Between

Underroot is not empty between the landings. Eight things can happen out there, and which one you get is simply **whether the movement die came up even or odd**. No table to look up, no second roll, no pause.

Thumpaw

Garnet dot, even. Plate D1.

A shape unfolds out of what you took for a boulder. It is the size of a cart horse, round and shaggy with matted brown moss growing over stone-grey hide, and it has hands like shovels. It looks at you with small patient eyes and does not move, because you are standing in the tunnel it was going to use.

1 **Thumpaw.** It will not move and it is directly in the way, and when somebody inevitably prods it, it swings.

- **This is a straight brawl and that is the point.** 76 hit points, two big slams a turn, no gimmick, no puzzle. Sometimes a table just wants to hit something large until it stops, and this is that.
- It never pursues and it never finishes a downed hero. It is grumpy, not evil.
- *(If the party genuinely tries to befriend it rather than fight it, DC 15 Animal Handling with advantage from Ursa's Mark will move it aside. Do not offer this. Let them think of it.)*

The Gleamoth

Garnet dot, odd. Plate D2.

The lights come round the corner before the sound does: forty pale green sparks drifting like blown seeds. They are moths, each the size of a hand, and every one of them is glowing, and they want the warmest thing in the tunnel, which is you.

3 **Gleamoth Swarms.** Not corrupted, just hungry for heat.

- They **blind and smother** rather than damage much, and they go for whoever is carrying light.
- **Fire and thunder scatter them fast;** anything that hits an area is worth double here.
- **The cost is the Sphere.** They are drawn to it hardest, so Lilly has the swarm on her the whole fight, which makes the party come to her.

The Deepwater Spring

Moss dot, even. Plate D3.

A crack in the wall, and inside it a still pool of water so clear that you can see forty feet down to the pale stones at the bottom. It is very cold, and it tastes like the air after lightning.

Everyone regains **1 Hit Die** and clears **one level of exhaustion**. Ghostbloom glows brighter for an hour and is insufferable about it.

The Shortcut

Moss dot, odd. Plate D4.

Something small and yellow-brown is standing on a mound ahead of you, up on its back legs, watching. When it is sure you have seen it, it drops down and starts digging, very fast, and the tunnel it opens goes exactly the way you were trying to go.

Advance the token 3 spaces free. If the party was unkind to it at Mosslight Landing, it watches them take the long way round instead, and that should sting.

Sinkloam

Ochre dot, even. Plate D5.

The floor stops being floor. It happens without a sound: one step is packed earth and the next is warm wet loam that comes up over your boots and keeps coming.

Everyone makes a **DC 13 Strength save** or is **restrained**, spending an action to pull free. Heavy armour has disadvantage, so Lilly is the one in trouble and somebody has to go back for her.

The Ceiling Lets Go

Ochre dot, odd. Plate D6.

Far above you, something enormous rolls over in its sleep, and the ceiling of the world lets go.

DC 14 Dexterity save, 2d10 bludgeoning on a fail, half on a success. The passage behind them is now blocked, which matters if anyone was planning to run.

The Reef Answers

Amethyst dot, even. Plate D7.

Somewhere far off, a single crystal note. Then another underneath it, and another, until the whole tunnel is ringing in a slow enormous chord you can feel in your ribs, and the moss on the walls lights up in time with it.

Everyone gains **2d8 temporary hit points** and Ghostbloom sings back, badly, at the top of her voice. **This is a good place for the short rest** if the party has not taken it yet.

The Guardian's Dream

Amethyst dot, odd. Plate D8.

For half a second all four of you see the same thing, and none of you asked for it.

An empty sea under an empty sky, going on forever. And something walking through it, huge and slow and patient, and where it walks the water shoulders aside and dry land comes up behind it, steaming, new.

Then it is gone and you are standing in a tunnel again.

No mechanical effect. **They have just seen Groudon remember his own job**, and they will not understand it until they are standing in front of him. Ursa may **regain one spent Omen Dream**, because something just spoke to him and he does not know what.

The Creatures

Formatted to match templates/build_bestiary.py; add them there when approved.

At Mosslight Landing

Rotbloom

Small plant (corrupted), unaligned. CR 1/2 (100 XP)

AC 12 **HP** 22 (4d6 + 8) **Speed** 25 ft.

STR 10 **DEX** 12 **CON** 14 **INT** 4 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 6

Resist poison **Imm.** (cond) blinded, deafened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 9

Challenge 1/2

Re-Bloom. At the start of its turn, if it took damage since its last turn and is not at 0 HP, it regains 5 hit points. It cannot re-bloom if it has taken radiant damage, or been hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Still Smiling. It cannot be frightened, and its face never changes, whatever is happening to it.

Cap Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (2d4 + 1) bludgeoning.

Spore Puff (Recharge 5-6). 10-ft cone, DC 12 Constitution save, 7 (2d6) poison and poisoned until the end of its next turn; half and no poisoning on a success.

Mossmite

Tiny beast (corrupted), unaligned. CR 1/8 (25 XP)

AC 13 **HP** 7 (2d4 + 2) **Speed** 40 ft., climb 40 ft.

STR 6 **DEX** 16 **CON** 12 **INT** 2 **WIS** 10 **CHA** 4

Senses blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 10 ♦ **Challenge** 1/8

Skitter. It does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Pack Nerve. It has advantage on attacks against a creature if another Mossmite is within 5 ft. of it.

Nip. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing.

At the Chime Reef

Chimestone

Medium elemental (Plane of Earth), unaligned. CR 3 (700 XP)

AC 16 (rock plate) **HP** 52 (7d8 + 21) **Speed** 25 ft.

STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 16 **INT** 5 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6

Resist piercing, slashing **Vuln.** thunder

Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses tremorsense 60 ft., passive Perception 11

Challenge 3

Resonant Body. Whenever it takes **thunder damage** it is **stunned** until the end of its next turn, and it takes **double damage** from every source while stunned. This is the intended way to beat them and it should feel devastating.

Struck Chord. A creature can use an action to strike one of the reef's large spires (DC 13 Athletics). Every Chimestone within 30 ft. makes a DC 14 Constitution save or is stunned as above. The striker takes 1d6 thunder damage from standing that close.

Multiattack. Two Crystal Rams.

Crystal Ram. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 11 (2d6 + 4) bludgeoning.

Shard Volley. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 40 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d8) piercing.

Shardwing

Small elemental, unaligned. CR 1 (200 XP)

AC 14 **HP** 22 (5d6 + 5) **Speed** 10 ft., fly 50 ft.

STR 8 **DEX** 18 **CON** 12 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6

Vuln. thunder ♦ **Imm.** poison ♦ (cond) poisoned, prone

Senses tremorsense 30 ft., passive Perception 11 ♦ **Challenge** 1

Glide. It can fly at full speed without provoking opportunity attacks from creatures it starts its turn adjacent to.

Dive. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d6 + 2) slashing. If it moved at least 30 ft. straight toward the target first, this deals an extra 1d6.

Shard Spit. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 60 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d10 + 2) piercing.

In the Glassed Gallery

Glass Weeper

Large plant (corrupted guardian-beast), unaligned. CR 6 (2,300 XP)

AC 16 (black glass) **HP** 115 (11d10 + 55) **Speed** 20 ft.

STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 20 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 5

Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons

Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, frightened, poisoned, prone

Senses blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 11

Challenge 6

Glassbound. It regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Rooted. It cannot move more than 15 ft. from the glassed roots it is tending, and it never tries to.

Tend the Roots (the clever play). A creature can use an action to clear or heal the roots near it: DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing spell cast on the roots rather than a creature. On a success the Weeper **loses Glassbound until the end of its next turn** and every attack against it has **advantage** until the start of the helper's next turn. This does not end the fight. It makes the party win it.

Multiattack. Three Frond Lashes.

Frond Lash. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing.

Keening (Recharge 5-6). 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution save, 21 (6d6) psychic and frightened until the end of its next turn; half and no fear on a success.

Cinderoll

Small elemental (corrupted), unaligned. CR 1/2 (100 XP)

AC 15 (glassy coal) **HP** 18 (4d6 + 4) **Speed** 40 ft. (rolling)

STR 12 **DEX** 14 **CON** 12 **INT** 3 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 3

Imm. fire, poison ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 9

Challenge 1/2

Rolling Charge. If it moves at least 20 ft. straight toward a target before hitting it, the attack deals an extra 3 (1d6) damage and the target makes a DC 12 Strength save or is knocked prone.

Burst. When it drops to 0 hit points it cracks open: each creature within 10 ft. makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 7 (2d6) fire damage. **They come in packs and this is the point.** Let the party work out that killing one next to three others is a chain reaction, and let them enjoy it.

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (2d4 + 2) bludgeoning plus 3 (1d6) fire.

In Groudon's Hollow

Groudon, the Continent-Maker

Gargantuan elemental (Plane of Earth, Guardian), unaligned. CR 11 (7,200 XP) as run here

AC 18 (mountain plate) **HP** 230 (but see The Spike) **Speed** 40 ft., burrow 40 ft.

STR 26 **DEX** 6 **CON** 24 **INT** 8 **WIS** 14 **CHA** 12

Resist all damage from nonmagical weapons **Imm.** fire, poison ♦ (cond) most

Senses tremorsense 120 ft., passive Perception 12

Challenge 11

THE SPIKE. This is the encounter. A shard of black glass is driven into his back at the shoulder. **AC 17, 60 hit points**, immune to all damage except **radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**. Reaching it requires climbing him, flying, or a ranged attack at disadvantage. **When the spike is destroyed the encounter ends immediately**, whatever Groudon's hit points are. Do not run him to 0. He is not supposed to die.

Unstoppable. He cannot be frightened, charmed, restrained, or knocked prone, and he ignores difficult terrain.

Agony. While the spike is intact, at the start of each of his turns he takes 10 damage and everything within 20 ft. makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or takes 10 (3d6) bludgeoning from the shockwave.

He Does Not Finish Them. When Groudon reduces a creature to 0 hit points, he immediately moves away from it. He is swatting at pain, not hunting children.

Continental Step. He moves up to his speed. Every creature on the ground within 30 ft. of his path makes a DC 16 Dex save or is knocked prone and takes 11 (2d10) bludgeoning.

Magma Vent (Recharge 4-6). A 60-ft line, 10 ft wide. DC 17 Dex save, 35 (10d6) fire, half on a success.

Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +12 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 22 (3d10 + 8) slashing.

Thrash (when the spike takes damage, 1/round, no action). Every creature climbing him makes a DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check or falls, taking 3d6 bludgeoning.

Glassling

Tiny construct (spawned by the spike), unaligned. CR 1/4 (50 XP)

AC 14 HP 10 (3d4 + 3) **Speed** 30 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR 8 DEX 16 CON 12 INT 1 WIS 6 CHA 1

Imm. poison, psychic ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 8 ♦ **Challenge** 1/4

Spike-Born. The spike creates one Glassling at the start of each of Groudon's turns. When the spike is destroyed, every Glassling collapses into ordinary sand immediately, wherever it is and whatever it was doing.

Shatterburst. At 0 hit points, each creature within 5 ft. makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 5 (2d4) slashing.

Glass Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing.

On the road between

Thumpaw

Large beast (Plane of Earth), unaligned. CR 3 (700 XP) ♦ random encounters only

AC 14 (mossy hide) **HP 76** (8d10 + 32) **Speed** 30 ft., burrow 30 ft.

STR 20 DEX 8 CON 18 INT 3 WIS 12 CHA 6

Senses tremorsense 60 ft., passive Perception 13 ♦ **Challenge** 3

Not Actually Angry. It does not attack until attacked, and it never pursues. It is in the way and it was there first.

Immovable. It has advantage on saves and checks against being moved, and it cannot be knocked prone.

Multiattack. Two Shovel Slams.

Shovel Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 14 (2d8 + 5) bludgeoning.

Gleammoth Swarm

Medium swarm of tiny beasts, unaligned. CR 1 (200 XP) ♦ random encounters only

AC 12 HP 26 (4d8 + 8) **Speed** 5 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)

STR 4 DEX 14 CON 14 INT 1 WIS 10 CHA 4

Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing **Vuln.** fire, thunder

Imm. (cond) charmed, frightened, grappled, prone, restrained, stunned

Senses blindsight 20 ft., passive Perception 10 ♦ **Challenge** 1

Drawn to Warmth. It always moves toward the warmest or brightest thing it can sense, which is the Essence Sphere. If Lilly is carrying it, the swarm goes for her every turn.

Swarm. It can occupy another creature's space and move through any opening large enough for a single moth.

Smother. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 0 ft., one creature in its space. *Hit:* 10 (4d4) piercing, or 5 (2d4) if the swarm is at half hit points or fewer, and the target is **blinded** until the end of its next turn.

The Resolution

When the spike breaks

Read aloud. *The black glass does not shatter. It comes apart like a held breath let go, all at once and quietly, into a spray of dark motes that hang in the air for a moment and then rush, all of them together, into the Sphere in Lilly's hands.*

And the mountain stops.

Groudon goes absolutely still, and then he lowers himself down onto his belly on the stone with a sound like a hillside settling, and he lets out a breath that goes on for eleven seconds, and every root in the hollow shivers.

Then he turns his head, slowly, and looks at the three of you properly for the first time.

He is not angry. He is so tired.

The Mote. As the glass leaves him, something else comes loose: a fist-sized, dense, red-brown ember of pure Earth, the piece of this plane's heart that was caught here. It drifts to the Sphere on its own. **This is the Mote of Terra.**

What Groudon does: he touches one claw, very carefully, to the ground in front of Ursa. Nobody needs the Mark to understand it. Then he starts to walk, and where he walks the cracks close behind him, and the black glass in the gallery greys and crumbles into ordinary soil.

Give Ursa this line if his player wants it: he is the only one who can feel what the creature is feeling, and what it is feeling is *relief*.

Antares

Ursa should be the one who notices, and it should happen after they step back through.

Read aloud, in Gearhaven. *You come out into lamplight and noise and Vane shouting, and it is a long few minutes before anybody looks up.*

Ursa does. Through the high windows of the Rift Hall, over the roofs of Gearhaven, there is a star in the east that was dying.

It is not dying now. It is the deep steady red it is supposed to be, and it is the first star in living memory to come back.

Only Ursa understands what he is looking at. He has spent a year with his father's charts. Let his player say it out loud to the others, and let Aelwyn go very quiet, because Aelwyn has just watched a theory become a fact.

The Staff of Waking Constellations does this, and it is what it was made for: one new star brightens on its haft.

The Aftermath

The homecoming, and the two creatures

This is the canon beat and it needs room.

Read aloud. *The Sphere will not settle.*

It has been getting brighter since Underroot and now it is too bright to look at directly, warm as a stove, humming against Lilly's palms. Aelwyn takes one look and tells everybody to stand back, and for once he is not delighted, he is nervous, which is much worse.

"It gathered more than it can hold," he says. "It only keeps one shape at a time. It is going to have to choose."

Ghostbloom chooses first. Nobody asks her to. She looks at Lilly, and chimes once, and steps into the light and is gone, and the Sphere goes calm.

Play this straight and let it hurt for a second. The kids will think they have lost her. They have not: she is the tether, she is fine, she can come back out, and Aelwyn explains that afterward. But give them three or four seconds of thinking otherwise before he does.

Then the gathered essence takes shape, and what steps out of the light is the small armoured digger from Mosslight Landing, blinking in the lamplight, entirely solid and entirely real.

- If they were kind to it in the Landing, it goes straight to whoever fed it.
- If they were not, it goes to Ursa, because his Mark is the warmest thing in the room, and that will sting in a way they deserve.

Aelwyn's explanation, in kid words: the Sphere gathers. It gathered a whole plane's worth of loose essence today, and essence gathers toward warmth and company, and so it brought somebody home.

The rule the party just learned: SWAPPING

Teach this properly. It is the mechanic the rest of the campaign runs on and this is its first outing.

- **The Sphere holds ONE physical companion at a time.** Everyone else rides inside it, safe and aware and perfectly fine.
- **Swapping takes a short rest,** done by whoever holds the Sphere. The one outside steps in, the one they choose steps out. Nobody is hurt by it and nobody is ever lost.
- **You choose before you go somewhere, not in the middle of a fight.** That is the interesting decision. Ghostbloom heals and senses planar things; Sandshrew digs and takes hits and is made of the same stuff as the ground. Picking wrong for a plane is a real mistake and an entirely survivable one.
- **The roster grows by one per rift.** Say that out loud. Four more planes, four more companions. The kids should start arguing immediately about who they want next, and they will be right to.

Release Sandshrew into their hands and let them do the first swap themselves that evening, just to prove it works and get Ghostbloom back out. Let them name the arrangement.

What each hero gets out of it

- **Lilly.** The Mote of Terra socketed into the Sphere. **Her first Elemental Discharge wakes: Tectonic Slam.** Four still sleep. Her power now grows by going out, exactly as she worked out during her year, and now she has proof.

Give her player this beat at the workbench that night. *She has the Sphere open, the Mote sitting in its new socket, and she is not looking at anybody.*

"It isn't full. That's the thing. There's a whole plane in there and it barely moved the needle." She turns it over in her hands. "I can feel where the other four go. There are sockets, and they're empty, and when I put my hand flat on it I can almost hear what it would sound like with all five."

"I don't think it's a battery. I think it's an instrument. And I've only ever played one note on it."

What that plants: her ceiling is very high and entirely gated on rifts cleared. She has gone from one discharge to a promise of five, and she is the only person at the table who can feel the shape of the thing she is going to become.

- **Ursa.** A relit star and the first hard evidence that the damage can be *undone*. Also the beginning of a private worry: the thing that put the spike in Groudon did it on purpose, and it has a name, and he brought that name home from a shrine.
- **Stabby.** The idol warmed up the moment they came back through, and he noticed exactly when. He still has not mentioned it to anybody.

Threads to leave hanging

1. **Who drove the spike in?** Nobody says the name at the table yet. But the party has now seen that the rifts are not weather. Somebody is doing this by hand.

2. **The idol.** Cold in Underroot, colder at the Gallery, warm at home.

3. **Four stars to go,** and two of them are still bright, which Aelwyn will realise before the next session is out means they can get there *first*.

The last line of the session, if you want one. Aelwyn is still looking east at Antares, and he says, to nobody: "One."

Still to build

- Bestiary entries for all ten Underroot creatures in `templates/build_bestiary.py`.
- Enemy artwork: **done.** Rotbloom, Mossmite, Chimestone, Shardwing, Cinderoll, Glassling, Glass Weeper, Thumpaw, Gleamoth swarm, and corrupted Groudon, plus six dot-event plates.
- A Tectonic Slam card for Lilly's sheet once the Mote is installed.